

BUZZLE

TABLETOP RULES

2-4 players | 217-cell honeycomb board | 7 tiles per rack

Set up

Use the 100-letter set, including two blanks, the assembled board, a bag and a scorepad. Mix the tiles face down. Each player draws seven and keeps them hidden. Choose a first player and take turns clockwise.

Agree to use the ARES word checker below so everyone uses the same word list. Highest final score wins.

Play a word

Place 1-7 rack tiles into empty cells along one straight hex line. Words may run along any of the three board axes. New tiles and any existing letters between them must make a continuous word with no gaps.

First turn: make a word of at least two letters covering the center star.

Later turns: connect to the existing hive by reusing letters or touching an occupied cell along an edge.

Check every new or extended word of two or more letters on all three axes. Each must be valid. A single tile may create several words. Existing tiles stay in place.

Finish your turn

Agree that every word is valid, add your score, then draw back to seven tiles while the bag allows. Announce the letter represented by a blank when placing it. That letter stays fixed; its value remains zero.

Exchange or pass

Instead of playing, exchange 1-7 rack tiles if the bag holds at least that many replacements. Draw replacements before returning and mixing the old tiles. The exchange uses your turn.

Or pass without changing your rack. A played word or exchange resets the consecutive-pass count.

Score every word

Add the printed letter values in each newly formed or extended word, including old letters. Score each distinct word once. Then add the scores of all words made by the play.

Bonus cells

Bonuses apply **only to tiles placed this turn**:

DL: double that letter. **TL:** triple it.

DW: double the whole word.

TW: triple the whole word.

Center star: double word on the opening.

DW / KEY: the normal DW bonus; no extra key bonus.

Apply letter bonuses before word bonuses. Multiple word bonuses multiply together. A new bonus tile counts in each word it helps make. A blank stays worth zero, but its word bonus still applies.

Use all seven: +50

Playing all seven rack tiles in one turn earns a 50-point Hive Flush after scoring the words.

Quick scoring example

CAT has C=3, A=1, T=1: 5 points. If the new C lands on DL, it is 6+1+1=8. If that same word also covers a new DW, it scores 16. Add any valid crossing words separately.

End the game

End when the bag is empty and a player uses their last tile, or after three full rounds of consecutive passes: 6 passes for two players, 9 for three, 12 for four.

Everyone subtracts the value of tiles left in their rack. If someone went out, they also add the total remaining tile values of the other players. After a pass ending, nobody receives that extra award. Highest score wins; a tie is a draw.

Dictionary, word checker and two-letter list:

aresfirst.org/buzzle/word-tools